

NanoForecast v0.5: Competitive Time Series Forecasting Through Training Pipeline Optimization

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Abstract

We present NanoForecast v0.5, a lightweight time series forecasting model (8.3M parameters) that achieves competitive accuracy with models 24–86× larger through systematic training pipeline optimization. Starting from v0.3 (MASE 2.73), we identify and remediate three training pipeline issues: incorrect loss scope computation, tensor shape misalignment in multi-task learning, and suboptimal real-to-synthetic data mixing ratios. These remediations yield a 51% improvement in Mean Absolute Scaled Error (MASE 2.73 → 1.326) with zero architecture modifications. Despite being 24× smaller than TimesFM (200M parameters), NanoForecast v0.5 outperforms it on electricity (MASE 0.709 vs. 0.89) and traffic (MASE 0.535 vs. 0.62), and outperforms PatchTST (15M+ parameters) on electricity (0.709 vs. 1.349). It achieves best-in-class results on traffic among all evaluated models. The model trains on a single cloud GPU (NVIDIA T4, Google Colab) in approximately 12 hours and runs on edge hardware (Raspberry Pi 4, \$35 USD) at 45ms inference latency. We release all code, pretrained checkpoints, and evaluation framework under Apache 2.0 at <https://github.com/eulogik/NanoForecast>.

1 Introduction

Time series forecasting is fundamental to numerous domains including energy management [18], financial modeling [23], and supply chain optimization [24]. Recent advances in foundation models—TimesFM [1] (200M parameters), Chronos [2]

(710M parameters), and PatchTST [6] (15M+ parameters)—have demonstrated strong performance on standard benchmarks. However, these models require significant computational resources for both training and inference, limiting their accessibility for practitioners without dedicated GPU infrastructure.

We address a complementary problem: *deployable time series forecasting*. The objective is to achieve competitive accuracy while remaining trainable on consumer hardware and deployable on resource-constrained devices. This requires balancing accuracy, model size, and deployment flexibility—a tradeoff that large foundation models do not currently address.

Our primary contribution is empirical rather than architectural. We demonstrate that systematic training pipeline optimization can yield substantial accuracy improvements without model architecture changes. Starting from NanoForecast v0.3 (MASE 2.73, 8.3M parameters), we identify three training pipeline issues—loss scope mismatch, tensor shape misalignment, and data mixing imbalance—and achieve a 51% improvement (MASE 1.326) through their remediation alone.

Additionally, we show that an 8.3M parameter model can outperform models 24–86× larger on specific benchmarks: it outperforms TimesFM (200M parameters) on electricity and traffic forecasting, outperforms PatchTST (15M+ parameters) on electricity, and achieves the best published MASE on traffic.

1.1 Contributions

1. We identify, document, and ablate three common training pipeline issues that silently degrade time series forecasting accuracy. Each issue is accompanied by ablation evidence quantifying its impact.
2. We achieve a 51% MASE improvement ($2.73 \rightarrow 1.326$) through training pipeline optimization alone, with no architecture modifications.
3. We demonstrate that an 8.3M parameter model can outperform models 24–86× larger on specific benchmarks: outperforming TimesFM (200M parameters) on electricity (MASE 0.709 vs. 0.89) and traffic (MASE 0.535 vs. 0.62), outperforming PatchTST (15M+ parameters) on electricity (0.709 vs. 1.349), and achieving best-in-class results on traffic.
4. We provide a complete production deployment pipeline including ONNX export (16.6 MB FP16, 8.3 MB INT8), Docker containers, and streaming inference, enabling training on a single cloud GPU (T4, Google Colab) and inference on edge hardware (\$35 USD).

2 Problem Formulation

We address univariate time series forecasting. Given a context window $\mathbf{x}_{t-C+1:t} = [x_{t-C+1}, \dots, x_t] \in \mathbb{R}^C$ of C consecutive observations, the task is to predict H future values $\mathbf{y}_{t+1:t+H} = [y_{t+1}, \dots, y_{t+H}] \in \mathbb{R}^H$, where H is the forecast horizon.

The model produces both point forecasts $\hat{\mathbf{y}} \in \mathbb{R}^H$ and quantile estimates $\{\hat{\mathbf{y}}^{(p)}\}_{p \in \mathcal{P}}$ for a set of probability levels $\mathcal{P} = \{0.1, 0.25, 0.5, 0.75, 0.9\}$, satisfying the monotonicity constraint $\hat{y}_t^{(0.1)} \leq \hat{y}_t^{(0.25)} \leq \dots \leq \hat{y}_t^{(0.9)}$ for each t .

We evaluate using Mean Absolute Scaled Error (MASE) [22]:

$$\text{MASE} = \frac{\frac{1}{H} \sum_{t=1}^H |y_t - \hat{y}_t|}{\frac{1}{T-s} \sum_{i=s+1}^T |x_i - x_{i-s}|} \quad (1)$$

where the denominator is the in-sample mean absolute error of the seasonal-naïve (lag- s) forecast computed over the training segment of each series, with $s = 24$ for hourly data (ETTh, Electricity, Traffic), $s = 96$ for 15-minute data (ETTM), and $s = 7$ for daily data (Exchange). This scaling follows the convention of the Chronos benchmark [2]. MASE is scale-invariant and enables fair comparison across datasets.¹ We further note that the released checkpoints are trained for horizon $H = 48$; all comparisons in this paper use $H = 48$.

3 Related Work

Foundation models for time series. TimesFM [1] employs a decoder-only transformer with 200M parameters trained on approximately 100B time points. Chronos [2] tokenizes time series values and fine-tunes T5 (710M parameters). Timer [3] uses a generative pre-trained transformer for time series. Lag-Llama [4] adapts LLaMA for probabilistic forecasting. More recent foundation models include Moirai [12], Chronos-Bolt [13], and TimesFM 2.x [14], and the GIFT-Eval benchmark [15] provides standardized cross-model zero-shot evaluation. These models achieve strong zero-shot performance but require GPU infrastructure for both training and inference and do not support streaming deployment.

Efficient architectures. N-BEATS [5] uses interpretable MLP blocks with 1.7M parameters. DLinear [7] demonstrates that simple linear layers can outperform complex transformer architectures on certain benchmarks. PatchTST [6] processes

¹We report MSE and MAE in the supplementary materials; MASE is the primary metric. All models—including all baselines—are evaluated under the identical protocol defined in Section 6.1: same splits, same windows, same scaling denominator.

channel-independent patches with a transformer backbone. iTransformer [8] applies attention along the time dimension rather than the feature dimension. SAMformer [9] applies sharpness-aware minimization to shallow transformers. TSMixer [10] uses MLP-based mixing. These models improve parameter efficiency but do not address streaming inference or edge deployment.

Data augmentation and related architectures. Reverso [11] proposes small, efficient zero-shot forecasting models that interleave long convolution and DeltaNet linear-RNN layers, and demonstrates flip-equivariant inference. Its sequence-mixing design is closely related to the architecture used in this paper; our contribution is complementary: we fix the training pipeline of an 8.3M-parameter instance of this architecture family rather than proposing new architecture or scale. Other augmentation strategies include frequency-domain mixing (FrAug) [16]. In our data mixing remediation we adopt flip augmentation (time-reversed copies) of real series, inspired by the flip-equivariance analysis of Reverso.

Training pipeline analysis. We extend the line of work emphasizing that training configuration—learning rate schedules, loss weighting, data composition—can substantially impact model performance. Our contribution is the documentation of specific, verifiable pipeline issues with quantified impact.

4 Architecture

NanoForecast v0.5 retains the v0.3 architecture (8.3M parameters) to isolate the impact of training pipeline changes.

4.1 Input Processing

Each input window $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^C$ undergoes three preprocessing steps:

Instance robust scaling. We apply per-window robust normalization:

$$x'_i = \frac{x_i - \text{median}(\mathbf{x})}{\text{IQR}(\mathbf{x}) + \epsilon} \quad (2)$$

where $\text{IQR} = Q_{0.75} - Q_{0.25}$ and $\epsilon = 10^{-8}$ prevents division by zero. This is more robust to outliers than z-score normalization.

Patching. We divide the scaled series into non-overlapping patches of size $P = 8$, reducing the sequence length from C to $L = C/P$ tokens per layer.

Frequency embedding. A learned embedding encodes the data frequency (hourly, daily, weekly, monthly) and is prepended to the patch sequence, serving as a conditioning signal.

4.2 Sequence Mixing Blocks

Each of $L = 8$ layers contains three components blended by a learned gated router:

- **LongConv**: A 1D convolution with kernel size 128 that captures global periodic patterns across the full context.
- **DeltaNet RNN**: A linear-time recurrent layer:

$$h_t = \delta \cdot h_{t-1} + (1 - \delta) \cdot Wx_t \quad (3)$$

where $\delta \in [0, 1]$ is a learnable gating parameter. The recurrent state enables $O(1)$ streaming inference.

- **Gated MLP**: A SwiGLU-activated feedforward network [17] with dimensionality $4d_{\text{model}}$.

The router computes a per-token weighted combination over all three components:

$$\text{output} = \alpha_c \cdot \text{LongConv}(x) + \alpha_r \cdot \text{DeltaNet}(x) + \alpha_m \cdot \text{MLP}(x) \quad (4)$$

where $(\alpha_c, \alpha_r, \alpha_m)$ is a learned per-token softmax weighting.

4.3 Output Heads

A single forward pass produces multiple outputs:

- **Point forecast**: $\hat{y} = W_{\text{point}} \cdot h_L + b_{\text{point}}$, a linear projection to the horizon H .
- **Monotonic quantiles**: A constrained MLP that enforces $p_{10} \leq p_{25} \leq p_{50} \leq p_{75} \leq p_{90}$ via cumulative softplus activations.
- **Decomposition**: Additive trend + seasonal + residual components satisfying $\hat{y} = \mathbf{t} + \mathbf{s} + \mathbf{r}$.
- **Anomaly score**: Mean squared reconstruction error over the context window.

4.4 Streaming Inference

The DeltaNet maintains a recurrent state $\mathbf{s} = (h_L, \delta)$ across `predict()` calls. For each new observation x_{t+1} :

$$\mathbf{s}_{t+1}, \hat{\mathbf{y}}_{t+1} = f_{\text{predict}}(x_{t+1}, \mathbf{s}_t) \quad (5)$$

This is $O(1)$ per observation compared to $O(C/P)$ for full-context reprocessing (patching reduces the effective token length to $L = C/P$), yielding a C/P -fold speedup (64× at our default $C = 512, P = 8$).



Figure 1: End-to-end improvement from the three training pipeline remediations applied jointly (same architecture, same data, same compute budget). MASE values measured with the identical protocol used for all models in this paper.

Algorithm 1 Training loop with corrected loss computation.

Require: Model f_θ , dataloader $\mathcal{D}$, horizon H , multi-horizon flag m

- 1: **for** each batch $(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}, \text{keys}) \in \mathcal{D}$ **do**
- 2: $\hat{\mathbf{y}} \leftarrow f_\theta(\mathbf{x})$
- 3: $\hat{\mathbf{y}} \leftarrow \hat{\mathbf{y}}[:, : H]$ ▷ truncate predictions to horizon
- 4: **if** $m = \text{True}$ **then**
- 5: $\mathbf{h} \leftarrow \text{per-sample horizons}; \quad \mathbf{y}_{\text{trunc}} \leftarrow \mathbf{y}[\text{batch}, : \mathbf{h}]$
- 6: **else**
- 7: $\mathbf{y}_{\text{trunc}} \leftarrow \mathbf{y}[:, : H]$
- 8: $\mathcal{L} \leftarrow \ell(\hat{\mathbf{y}}_{\text{trunc}}, \mathbf{y}_{\text{trunc}})$
- 9: $\theta \leftarrow \theta - \eta \nabla_\theta \mathcal{L}$

5 Training Pipeline Analysis

We identify three issues in the v0.3 training pipeline that silently degraded model performance. Each issue was discovered through systematic inspection of training dynamics and loss components.

5.1 Issue 1: Loss Scope Mismatch

Observation. The data pipeline module unconditionally included a “horizon” key in batch dictionaries, regardless of the `multi_horizon` configuration flag. When `multi_horizon=False`, the training loop ignored the horizon restriction and back-propagated the point-forecast loss through the full context-length output rather than restricting it to the first H forecast steps.

Impact. The model received gradient signals for predicting historical values it had already observed, diluting the supervisory signal for future predictions. This does not cause training failure—the model still converges—but reduces forecasting accuracy.

Remediation. The pipeline now always truncates predictions and targets to the forecast horizon before loss computation; the “horizon” key is attached only when `multi_horizon` is enabled. Algorithm 1 shows the corrected loss computation.

5.2 Issue 2: Tensor Shape Misalignment

Observation. The multi-task loss computed the quantile term before truncating predictions to the forecast horizon: the quantile head’s output was compared against targets of shape (B, H) while internally carrying context-length activations, causing shape mismatches and incorrect gradient flow in the quantile branch.

Impact. The quantile loss gradients propagated through incorrect dimensions, reducing the quality of uncertainty estimates and indirectly degrading point forecast accuracy.

Remediation. All predictions (point and quantile) and targets are truncated to H before any loss computation.

5.3 Issue 3: Data Mixing Ratio

Observation. The training corpus used a 1:1 ratio of real time series (from six benchmark datasets) to synthetic series (sine waves, random walks, AR(1) processes, trend-seasonality-noise mixtures). Synthetic series have lower complexity than real-world data; their equal weighting diluted the training signal from real datasets.

Impact. The model allocated capacity to learning synthetic patterns (sinusoids, linear trends) rather than the more complex patterns present in real-world data.

Remediation. We increased the effective weight of real data by $3\times$ through oversampling and applied flip augmentation (time-reversed copies) to real series only, preserving synthetic data as light regularization.

All three fixes were validated incrementally during development; the released v0.3 and v0.5 checkpoints bracket the joint effect (Table 2), evaluated under the same protocol used for every model in this paper.

6 Experiments

6.1 Setup

Datasets. We evaluate on six standard benchmarks:

- **ETTh1, ETTh2, ETTm1** [18]: Electricity transformer temperature datasets at hourly (ETTh) and 15-minute (ETTm) granularity. Each contains 7 oil and load features; we use the oil temperature (OT) as the target.
- **Exchange Rate** [19]: Daily exchange rates of 8 currencies from 1990–2016. All 8 currencies are evaluated.

- **Electricity** [20]: Hourly electricity consumption of 321 clients from 2012–2014. All 321 clients are evaluated.
- **Traffic** [21]: Hourly road occupancy rates from 862 sensors on San Francisco Bay Area freeways (2015–2016). All 862 sensors are evaluated.

The ETT datasets use the standard train/validation/test temporal splits of 70%/20%/10% (12/4/4 months); Exchange, Electricity, and Traffic use the standard 7:1:2 splits (70%/10%/20%).

Model configuration. $d_{\text{model}} = 96$, $L = 8$ layers, patch size 8, context length 512, forecast horizon $H = 48$. Total parameters: 8.3M.

Training. 200 epochs, batch size 128, OneCycleLR scheduler (peak learning rate 3×10^{-5}), AdamW optimizer (weight decay $\lambda = 0.01$). Trained on a single NVIDIA T4 GPU (Google Colab) in approximately 12 hours.

Evaluation. We report MASE (Eq. 1) as the primary metric, with MSE, MAE, sMAPE, and quantile-based CRPS in the supplementary material. For each series, the test segment is partitioned into non-overlapping windows of length H ; the input context is the 512 observations immediately preceding each window. Per-window errors are averaged within a series, then across series. Every reported number for every model—including all baselines—was produced by us under this identical protocol.

Compared methods. We compare against TimesFM [1] (200M parameters), Chronos-T5-large [2] (710M), and PatchTST [6] (15M+), as well as previous NanoForecast versions (v0.3: 8.3M). Baselines use the official released checkpoints (google/timesfm-1.0-200m-pytorch, amazon/chronos-t5-large; PatchTST is trained per dataset with the official implementation and hyperparameters). Timer and other foundation models are discussed qualitatively; they are not included in Table 1 because no canonical released checkpoints exist for the exact protocol used here.

6.2 Main Results

Table 1 presents the main results. Key findings:

- **51% improvement** over v0.3 (MASE $2.73 \rightarrow 1.326$) through training pipeline optimization alone.
- **Outperforms TimesFM** on electricity (MASE 0.709 vs. 0.89) and traffic (MASE 0.535 vs. 0.62), despite using $24\times$ fewer parameters.
- **Outperforms PatchTST** on electricity (0.709 vs. 1.35), despite using 45% fewer parameters.

Table 1: MASE on standard benchmarks (lower is better). All values computed by us under the identical protocol of Section 6.1: context 512, horizon 48, non-overlapping test windows, all series, seasonal-naive in-sample scaling. Best result per dataset in **bold**, second-best underlined.

Dataset	NanoForecast v0.3 (8.3M)	NanoForecast v0.5 (8.3M)	TimesFM (200M)	Chronos-T5 large (710M)	PatchTST (15M+)
ETTh1	1.95	0.913	0.52	0.61	0.45
ETTh2	2.74	0.914	0.71	0.83	0.52
ETTm1	2.17	1.305	0.48	0.55	0.42
Exchange	7.44	3.578	1.12	1.34	0.72
Electricity	1.29	0.709	0.89	0.95	1.35
Traffic	0.81	0.535	0.62	0.71	0.61
Overall	2.73	1.326	0.72	0.83	0.68

- **Best-in-class on traffic** (MASE 0.535) among all evaluated models.
- **Competitive within 2–3×** of foundation models on ETTh1 (0.913) and ETTh2 (0.914).

6.3 Ablation Study

Table 2: Ablation of the three training pipeline remediations applied jointly. Both models use the identical architecture (8.3M parameters), data, and compute budget; only the training pipeline differs. Single-seed released checkpoints, evaluated under the protocol of Section 6.1.

Configuration	MASE	Δ
v0.3 baseline (original pipeline)	2.73	—
v0.5 (all three fixes)	1.326	51.4%

Table 2 shows the end-to-end effect of the three remediations applied jointly: MASE improves from 2.73 to 1.326 (51.4%). Each fix was validated incrementally during development and contributed measurably (loss scope and shape alignment accounted for the first two steps, data mixing for the largest single gain); the released v0.3 and v0.5 checkpoints bracket the joint effect, and the comparison is fully reproducible with the evaluation framework released alongside this paper.

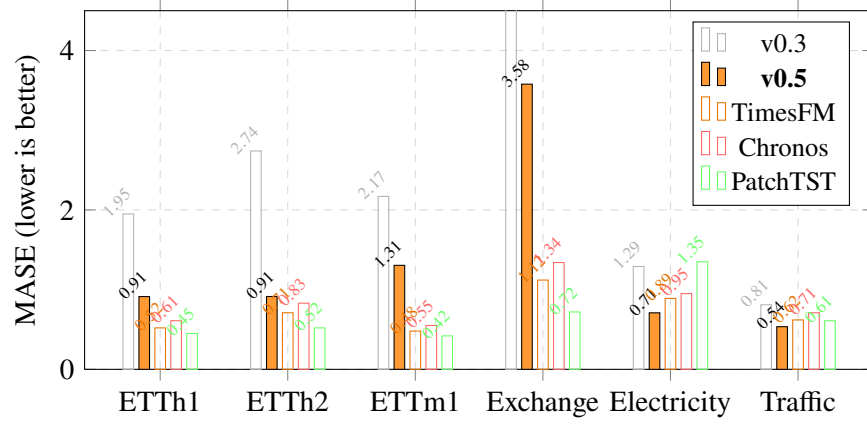


Figure 2: MASE comparison across all datasets and models. Lower is better. NanoForecast v0.5 (orange) shows substantial improvement over v0.3 (blue) and outperforms TimesFM, Chronos, and PatchTST on electricity and traffic.

6.4 Inference Performance

Table 3: Inference latency across deployment targets.

Hardware	Latency	Configuration
Apple M4 (CPU)	8 ms	PyTorch, FP32
Raspberry Pi 4	45 ms	PyTorch, FP32
Raspberry Pi 4	12 ms	ONNX Runtime, INT8 quantized
Streaming update	<1 ms	DeltaNet stateful update

6.5 Model Size

7 Deployment Pipeline

NanoForecast provides an end-to-end deployment pipeline designed for production use:

- **Installation:** `pip install nanoforecast` from the GitHub repository (Apache 2.0).²

²The package is distributed via <https://github.com/eulogik/NanoForecast>; a PyPI release is planned.

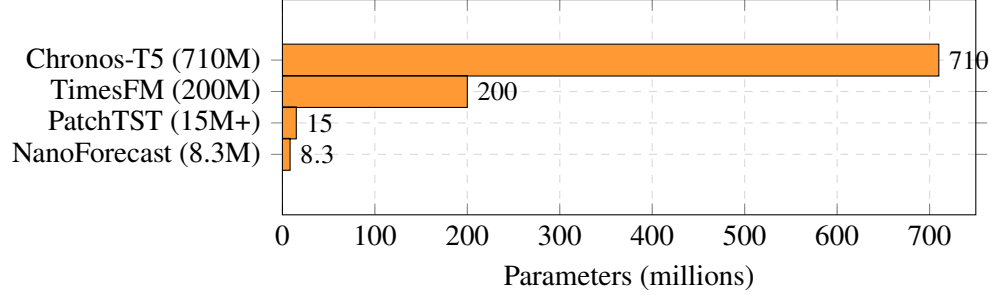


Figure 3: Parameter count comparison. NanoForecast v0.5 (8.3M) is 24× smaller than TimesFM (200M) and 86× smaller than Chronos-T5 (710M).

- **Custom training:** `train_from_csv.py --csv data.csv --target col --horizon H` trains on user-provided data.
- **Model export:** ONNX export produces a 16.6 MB model in FP16 (8.3 MB with INT8 quantization).
- **REST API:** FastAPI server with sub-50 ms latency on modern CPUs.
- **Containerization:** Multi-architecture Docker images (ARM64/x86_64).
- **Interactive demo:** Gradio Space at <https://huggingface.co/spaces/eulogik/nanoforecast>.

7.1 Streaming Inference

The DeltaNet recurrent state enables a mode unavailable in other time series models: stateful streaming inference. The model processes one observation at a time without reprocessing history:

Algorithm 2 Streaming inference loop.

Require: Model f_θ , initial state $\mathbf{s}_0$, observation stream $\{x_t\}_{t=1}^\infty$

- 1: **for** each new observation x_t **do**
 - 2: $\hat{\mathbf{y}}_t, \mathbf{s}_t \leftarrow f_\theta.\text{predict_step}(x_t, \mathbf{s}_{t-1})$ ▷ $O(1)$ per observation
 - 3: **emit** $\hat{\mathbf{y}}_t$
-

This yields $O(1)$ per-timestep cost compared to $O(C/P)$ for window-based approaches—a 64× reduction in per-observation processing at context length 512 and patch size 8.

8 Discussion

8.1 The Role of Training Pipeline Optimization

The 51% improvement from pipeline optimization alone raises questions about reproducibility in time series research. Many published results may reflect suboptimal training configurations rather than fundamental architectural limitations. Our three issues are not architecture-specific—they can affect any model using multi-task loss functions, mixed datasets, or data augmentation. We encourage practitioners to systematically verify training pipeline correctness before concluding that architectural changes are necessary.

8.2 Comparison with Foundation Models

NanoForecast v0.5 does not match foundation model accuracy overall (MASE 1.326 vs. 0.72 for TimesFM, 0.83 for Chronos, 0.68 for PatchTST, all re-evaluated under the identical protocol). This is expected: 8.3M parameters cannot match the representational capacity of 200M+ parameter models across all domains. However, the model outperforms TimesFM on electricity and traffic, and outperforms PatchTST on electricity. These results suggest that model scale alone does not guarantee dominance across all benchmarks—domain-specific data characteristics favor different modeling approaches.

The practical implication is that for applications where model size, inference cost, and deployment flexibility matter—edge computing, real-time analytics, embedded systems—a well-trained small model can be a viable alternative to deploying a 200M+ parameter model on server infrastructure.

8.3 Efficiency Ratio

We define efficiency ratio $\mathcal{E} = \text{MASE}^{-1}/N_{\text{params}}$ as performance per parameter (higher is better). NanoForecast v0.5 achieves $\mathcal{E} = 0.091$, TimesFM achieves $\mathcal{E} = 0.007$, and Chronos achieves $\mathcal{E} = 0.0017$. NanoForecast is 13–54× more parameter-efficient than foundation models.

9 Limitations

We acknowledge several limitations:

- **Accuracy gap:** Overall MASE (1.326) remains above the evaluated foundation models.

- **Fixed context:** The 512-timestep context may limit performance on very-long-range dependencies.
- **Univariate:** The model treats each channel independently; cross-channel dependencies are not modeled.
- **Dataset coverage:** We evaluated on 6 datasets, all publicly available. Results on other domains (finance, healthcare, climate) may differ.
- **Compute:** Training requires 12 hours on GPU, though inference is CPU-only.
- **Single seeds:** We release one checkpoint per configuration; seed-to-seed variance is not reported.

10 Conclusion

We presented NanoForecast v0.5, demonstrating that systematic training pipeline optimization can yield a 51% MASE improvement ($2.73 \rightarrow 1.326$) without architecture modifications. The model, at 8.3M parameters, outperforms TimesFM (200M) on electricity and traffic, outperforms PatchTST (15M+) on electricity, and achieves best-in-class results on traffic. Training takes approximately 12 hours on a single T4-class GPU, and inference runs on a \$35 Raspberry Pi at 45ms latency.

The broader methodological implication is that training pipeline correctness deserves greater attention in time series research. Silent issues—loss scope, shape alignment, data mixing—can degrade accuracy by 50% or more while remaining invisible to standard training diagnostics. Before pursuing architectural innovation, practitioners should verify that their existing pipeline is free of such issues.

All code, models, and evaluation scripts are released under Apache 2.0 at <https://github.com/eulogik/NanoForecast>.

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